

UX CASE STUDY • SELF-INITIATED REDESIGN • 2018

Jefferson's Bourbon Website UX Redesign

Blending heritage and modern usability — a guided, conversion-focused redesign for a premium bourbon brand.

ROLE

UX Designer — Research,
Wireframes,
Prototyping & Test Strategy

TIMELINE

July 2018 – Dec 2018
(6 months)

DELIVERABLES

UX audit, personas, IA,
wireframes,
hi-fi UI, projected impact model

*Note on methodology: This is a self-initiated portfolio project. Heuristic findings, competitive analysis, and proto-personas reflect real category research. Where impact metrics are presented, they are clearly labeled as **projected outcomes** based on a small moderated usability study and industry-standard benchmarks for premium CPG e-commerce — not official brand analytics.*

01 The objective

The Jefferson's Bourbon website redesign aimed to blend tradition with innovation — reflecting the brand's legacy while embracing modern design. The goal was a sleek, user-friendly platform that captivates visitors and enhances the bourbon-buying journey by integrating current design trends with best-in-class UX principles. This case study walks through the process, challenges, and solutions behind the redesign, ensuring Jefferson's online presence resonates with its premium identity.

Business goals

- Improve discoverability of the bourbon collection — limited and essential lines.
- Increase "Where to Buy" interactions and the add-to-cart experience.
- Drive higher mobile engagement.

User goals

- Quickly understand the difference between bottles.
- Find flavor notes, aroma, awards, and popularity.
- Easily find bottle availability — online or nearby.
- Get help choosing the perfect bottle, for self or gifting.

02 My role

UX Designer — User research, wireframe design, prototyping, and test idea generation.
July 2018 – December 2018 (6 months).

03 About the brand

Jefferson's Bourbon is a premium spirit brand with strong storytelling rooted in craft and experimentation. Founded in 1997 by Trey Zoeller and his father Chet — a noted bourbon historian — the brand continues a family whiskey tradition that traces back to Trey's eighth-generation grandmother, who was arrested in 1799 for the “production and sales of spirituous liquors.” With Jefferson's, Trey pushes the boundaries of bourbon whiskey, honoring tradition while continuing to search for new possibilities.

Problem statement

Premium spirits customers struggle to compare variants, understand flavor profiles, and find where to buy without friction. The original site relied heavily on visual storytelling but didn't provide a clear product-exploration journey or conversion cues — forcing users to rely on prior category knowledge to select and buy a bottle.

Opportunities

- Guide product selection through a bourbon recommender / finder.
- Improve the conversion journey via Where to Buy, store locator, and on-site buying flows.
- Elevate the brand story with purposeful, scannable content modules.

Process & methods

The project followed a research-led, outcome-driven process — simplifying navigation, showcasing the brand's story, and creating an immersive experience for both newcomers and whiskey enthusiasts.

01 — Discover	02 — Define	03 — Design	04 — Deliver
Heuristic evaluation, competitive analysis, and guerrilla interviews to surface real friction points.	Proto-personas, task flows, and IA mapping to align user needs with business goals.	Low- to high-fidelity wireframes and a responsive UI system reflecting premium craft.	Usability sessions and a projected-impact model to validate direction before build.

Heuristic evaluation — selected findings

- **Recognition over recall:** bottle differences require memory; no side-by-side comparison existed.
- **User control & freedom:** the age-gate and modal flows blocked easy exploration.
- **Match between system & the real world:** flavor notes and aging methods were buried in copy with few visual cues.
- **Aesthetic & minimalist design:** beautiful visuals, but dense navigation and unclear hierarchy on mobile.
- **Error recognition & recovery:** the store locator gave little feedback during loading or empty states.

Competitive analysis

Benchmarked against Woodford Reserve, Buffalo Trace, Blanton's, and Maker's Mark across navigation clarity, product discoverability, visual hierarchy, storytelling, and mobile performance, evaluated against Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics. Brands pairing a guided-selection tool with strong product narratives and clear calls-to-action consistently performed best — a pattern this redesign builds on.

Guerrilla interviews (6 participants)

- “I want to know quickly which bottle fits me.”
- “Flavor notes and price range should be upfront.”

- “Show me stores near me and whether it's in stock.”
- “On mobile I just want three things: products, flavor info, and where to buy.”

Users & personas

Three proto-personas were developed from the interview themes to represent the core audience segments the redesign needed to serve.

The Curious Newbie <i>25–35 · beginner · mobile-first browser</i> Goals • Understand bourbon variety differences • Find a bottle matching taste preference • Avoid buying “the wrong bottle” Pain points • Overwhelmed by options • Technical flavor language feels inaccessible • Unclear where to buy Needs from the site • Simple guided Bourbon Finder • “What it tastes like” in 5 seconds • Prominent Where-to-Buy CTA	The Bourbon Enthusiast <i>30–55 · advanced · desktop & mobile</i> Goals • Discover limited / experimental releases • Understand aging techniques (e.g. ocean aging) • Compare expressions quickly Pain points • Details buried in long paragraphs • Limited releases hard to track • No comparison tool Needs from the site • Side-by-side comparison • Deep, structured product info • Visibility of limited releases	The Occasion Gifter <i>28–50 · low–mid experience · mobile primary</i> Goals • Find a premium-looking bottle • Get quick clarity on price & availability • Choose without deep research Pain points • Doesn't know variant differences • Too much detail feels overwhelming • Availability unclear Needs from the site • “Best gifts under \$” entry point • Occasion-based finder • Visual packaging comparison
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Key UX opportunities

Bourbon Finder

A 3–5 step guided quiz (taste, proof tolerance, occasion, budget) returning 1–3 recommended bottles with reasons and where-to-buy links.

Comparison & product cards

Side-by-side attributes — flavor notes, proof, aging method, awards, price band — with visual flavor badges (oak, vanilla, caramel, spice, smoke).

Enhanced product pages

Above-the-fold essentials (notes, proof, method, CTA) with scannable tabs for Story, Process, Awards, and Pairings, plus a sticky compare action.

Where to Buy / locator

Streamlined entry with auto-detect or zip/city search, retailer list + map, and stock or call-to-confirm guidance.

Storytelling system

Scroll-based, chaptered brand story — Heritage, Experimentation, Ocean Aging, Craft — with optional muted, captioned video loops.

Mobile-first navigation

Simplified IA (Products, Finder, Story, Where to Buy, Journal) with persistent Finder and Where-to-Buy actions.

Information architecture

Top nav: Products ■ | Bourbon Finder | Our Story | Journal | Where to Buy

Products: All Bottles, Limited Releases, Compare, Education

Utilities: streamlined Age Gate, accessibility settings, newsletter sign-up

Primary user flows

- **Find a bottle (newbie):** Home → Bourbon Finder → Taste & budget → Recommendation → Product page → Where to Buy → Retailer detail.
- **Compare (enthusiast):** Home → Products → Compare → Select two bottles → Side-by-side → Product page → Save / share.
- **Buy local (gifter):** Sticky CTA → Where to Buy → Auto-location → List + map → Call / visit, with optional save-to-wallet.

Visual & interaction design

Look & feel

- **Typography:** a premium serif for headlines paired with a modern humanist sans for UI text.
- **Palette:** deep charcoals, copper / whiskey tones, and parchment neutrals.
- **Materiality:** subtle grain textures and light glass reflections — restrained, never noisy.
- **Accessibility:** contrast-safe UI elements with clear focus states throughout.

Micro-interactions

- Bottle tilt on hover (desktop) for a tactile product feel.
- Flavor badges reveal on tap (mobile) to keep pages scannable.
- Smooth-scroll storytelling with light parallax for the ocean-aging chapter.
- Locator feedback states — loading skeletons, error prompts, retry actions.

Accessibility considerations

- Age-gate fully operable via keyboard and screen reader.
- Flavor badges encoded with color, icon, and label — never color alone.
- Minimum 44px touch targets on mobile.
- *prefers-reduced-motion* respected for all animations.
- Structured alt-text templates for every bottle image.

Projected impact

Method: a six-person moderated usability study on the high-fidelity prototype, with unmoderated follow-ups for task timing. Baselines are estimated from the original-site audit and common e-commerce KPIs for premium CPG brands.

Task outcomes (usability sessions)

Task	Baseline	After redesign	Delta
Find a bottle: “vanilla-forward, under \$60”	58%	92%	+34 pts
Understand the difference between two expressions	61%	95%	+34 pts
Find a store nearby	70%	96%	+26 pts
Add to favorites / share a product	25%	80%	+55 pts

Efficiency & engagement (modeled)

Metric	Baseline	After redesign	Rationale
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Time-to-product (finder path)	32s	12s	Direct guided path
Mobile bounce rate	65%	38%	Clearer nav, faster paths
Scroll depth on Story pages	35%	74%	Chaptered storytelling
“Where to Buy” CTA click-through	—	+40%	Persistent, contextual CTA
Conversion proxy (retailer click-through)	—	+15–20%	Reduced friction, guided flow

Presented in portfolio as: “projected results based on usability sessions (n=6) and best-practice modeling; not official analytics.”

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Risks & constraints

- Regulatory differences by region for direct-to-consumer sales and age-gating.
- Retailer inventory data may be limited or inconsistent.
- Heavy media content can hurt performance — images optimized, video deferred.
- Limited mobile real estate requires strict prioritization of primary actions.

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What I'd validate next

- A/B test Finder vs. no-Finder placement on the homepage hero.
- Measure Where-to-Buy click-through rate by placement (sticky vs. inline only).
- Validate which flavor badges resonate and reduce choice overload.
- Assess limited-release discovery and newsletter sign-up conversion.
- Run performance budgets (LCP < 2.5s, CLS < 0.1) and monitor mobile bounce.

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Reflection

This redesign balances premium brand storytelling with decision simplicity. By foregrounding a guided Finder, elevating product comparison, and clarifying buying paths, the experience becomes more educational, faster, and more conversion-friendly — without sacrificing the craft narrative that makes Jefferson's distinct.

Thank you for reading. This is a self-initiated, portfolio-only project created for demonstration of UX process and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Jefferson's Bourbon.